

Sean Olmstead Artist Statement

I am a multimedia artist working with video, sound, performance, and installation to explore perceptions of time and space, cultural and personal relationships to media, and self-referential systems.

At times I rely heavily on analog electronic media. The tools for these explorations include video cameras, VCRs, modular synthesizers, transducers, and CRT televisions. Exploring the analog realm relies on active voltages which pulse and circulate like vascular systems through the work, giving it a sense of vitality, dynamism, and urgency. These pieces are not static. They live and breathe, flirting with the ever present possibility of breakdown and failure.

My experiments with analog video have touched upon the work of artists like Alvin Lucier, asking how memory changes over time. Video compositing and VHS dubbing create sequentially degraded multiplicities through “generation loss” while allowing disparate times to exist in simultaneity. The present gazes at once over the landscape of all times past.

In other examples of my work, I embrace digital forms and workflows. I chop up audio ranging from ambient found sounds, to white noise, AI chatbots, to crowd sourced chanting in order to create new textures and landscapes, greater than the sum of their parts. Recent processes have involved creating bespoke programs in the Python programming language to run on microcontrollers like Raspberry Pi to allow autonomous control of sound and video environments.

Regardless of the creative approach, my explorations of electronic media aim to subvert and challenge our expected experience and relationship with these media. By debasing and obfuscating their intended utility, even allowing them to transmit and receive seemingly of their own accord, I prod at notions of information, communication, and authorship.

To augment the media aspect of my work, I often include sculptural elements. These typically take a crudely crafted approach to materials like sheet metal, wood, concrete, and rebar, as well as exposed electronic elements. The rawness of these material implementations evoke basement tinkerers and junkyard rummagers. The results are an anachronistic and at times paranoid treatise on cultural and technological modernity.

A through line of humor is present in much of my work. Sometimes I insert myself—bodily, vocally, or otherwise—into the pieces in surprising or uncomfortable ways. Or I record and play a cacophonous choir of AI chatbots paying me compliments and occasionally panting. Simple robotics or electronics compelled by sensors suggest flawed and malfunctioning technologies. Humor to me is one of the purest forms of communication and connection both with the world with which my art is engaging, and with the audience to whom I speak. It serves as a buffer and even a coping mechanism for processing a world which I so frequently find absurd and alien.